

PHRASAL VERBS

Meaning of Phrasal Verbs

A phrasal verb is a combination of a main verb and one or two particles (a preposition or an adverb) which together form a new meaning different from the original verb.

Formula:

Verb + Preposition / Adverb = New Meaning

Examples

Verb	Particle.	Phrasal Verb	Meaning
look	after	look after	to take care of
give	up	give up	to stop trying
turn	on	turn on	to switch on
break	down	break down.	to stop working

Types of Phrasal Verbs

1. Transitive Phrasal Verbs

These phrasal verbs require an object.

Examples:

She called off the meeting.

I will pick up the book.

Some transitive phrasal verbs can be separated:

She turned off the light.

She turned the light off.

☐ If the object is a pronoun, it must come between the verb and the particle:

Correct: Turn it off.

Incorrect: Turn off it.

2. Intransitive Phrasal Verbs

These do not require an object.

Examples:

The car broke down.

He woke up late.

Separable and Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

Separable Phrasal Verbs

The verb and particle can be separated by an object.

Examples:

Put on your shoes.

Put your shoes on.

Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

The verb and particle must stay together.

Examples:

She ran into her teacher.

We are looking for the keys.

Ran her teacher into (Wrong)

Common Phrasal Verbs and Meanings

Phrasal Verb	Meaning
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bring up	to raise a topic
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carry on	to continue
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come across	to find by chance
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find out	to discover
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look forward to	to be excited about
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put off	to postpone
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set up to establish

take off to remove or to fly

Importance of Phrasal Verbs

They are commonly used in spoken and written English

They help improve fluency and comprehension

They are frequently tested in examinations

Summary

Phrasal verbs consist of a verb + particle

They may be transitive or intransitive

Some are separable, others are inseparable

Their meanings are often idiomatic

Practice Exercise

Underline the phrasal verb in each sentence:

1. The teacher called off the test.
2. Please turn off the fan.
3. She ran into an old friend.